

The decision journal

Write down what you decided, what you expect to happen and how sure you are. Put it away. On a date you set now, write what actually happened. A year of sheets tells you where your judgement can be trusted.

FOR ANY KIND OF THING, AFTERWARDS · PETER DRUCKER'S FEEDBACK ANALYSIS, 1999 · TAKES TEN MINUTES NOW, TEN MINUTES LATER

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write the decision and today's date. Then write a review date at the top, three, six or twelve months out, and put it in a calendar now. The sheet is useless without it.
2. What you decided and why, in the words you would use to someone who disagreed. The options you turned down, in a line each.
3. What you expect to happen, by when, as something you could check later. Then how sure you are, as a number. Circle it. Fifty is a coin toss; ninety-nine is a promise.
4. What would tell you that you were wrong. And how you are today: tired, rushed, angry, well. State leaks into decisions, and you will not remember it later.
5. Put the sheet away and do not reread it. On the review date, before you look at what you wrote, write what actually happened.
6. Then compare. Right about the outcome? Right for the reasons you gave? What you would do differently, and what this says about your judgement on this kind of decision. After a dozen sheets the patterns show, and that is the point.

Where it falls down. Reviewing only the decisions that went well, or quietly rewriting the expectation once you know the outcome. The date at the top and the sheet in a drawer are the defences.

WITH A PEN

The decision, and today's date

Review on

A date, in the calendar now

What I decided, and why

As I would say it to someone who disagreed. The options I turned down

What I expect to happen, by when

Something I could check

How sure I am

50 60 70 80 90 99 per cent. Circle one

What would tell me I was wrong

How I am today

Tired, rushed, angry, well

Review: what actually happened

Written before rereading the top half

Right about the outcome? Right for the reasons?

What I'd do differently. What this says about my judgement on this kind of decision